

Music

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Grade boundaries

Higher level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 10	11 - 21	22 - 38	39 - 52	53 - 66	67 - 80	81 - 100

Standard level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 10	11 - 20	21 - 38	39 - 51	52 - 64	65 - 77	78 - 100

Exploring music in context

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 2	3 - 4	5 - 8	9 - 11	12 - 14	15 - 17	18 - 24

Experimenting with music

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 2	3 - 4	5 - 10	11 - 14	15 - 17	18 - 21	22 - 28

Higher level the contemporary music maker

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 3	4 - 7	8 - 12	13 - 17	18 - 22	23 - 27	28 - 32

Presenting music

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 5	6 - 10	11 - 16	17 - 21	22 - 27	28 - 32	33 - 38

Exploring music in context

The range and suitability of the work submitted

This session there were some compelling submissions, but in many instances there appeared to be a lack of understanding of the specific demands of this component. A key misunderstanding lies in the purpose of aspects such as criteria C1 and C2, which are not necessarily intended to measure musical expressiveness, but rather to evaluate the student's understanding of stylistic conventions and performance practices. In several cases, students submitted work that might have been imaginative and engaging yet overlooked essential requirements of the task. As a result, these submissions, despite their artistic merit, did not achieve high marks, or in some cases, any marks at all.

Student performance against each criterion

This section will focus on describing areas that need attention from supervisors and students. In the section "Recommendation for the supervision of future students" we will make a brief analysis of those cases where students reached high marks to be used as examples for subsequent sessions.

Criterion A

A limited range of musical selections was observed across student submissions. It appears that the same pieces such as *Libertango*, *Strange Fruit*, and *The Girl from Ipanema* continue to attract many students, which undermines the goal of encouraging broader musical exploration.

A recurring issue was the lack of clear and persuasive justification for the Areas of Inquiry (AOIs) and contexts. In numerous cases, justifications were either unconvincing or inconsistent with the actual characteristics of the selected works.

Several concerns were also noted regarding the presentation of evidence. A significant number of musical examples omitted essential notational elements, such as clefs. Furthermore, many student comments lacked in-text citations, and the timestamps referenced often related to external musical clips rather than the materials provided in Upload 3, rendering them inaccessible to examiners.

There was also evident confusion regarding the appropriate classification of music used in film. For instance, some students referenced pre-existing music (e.g., works by Beethoven or Chopin) used in cinematic contexts without acknowledging that these pieces were not composed specifically for film. This contrasted with examples such as the Star Wars score, in which the music was purposefully written to support the visual narrative. Similarly, in cases involving music composed for dramatic effect, such as dance music, students sometimes failed to connect the music's function to their rationale for selecting AOI 3. In these cases, analyses focused on describing musical elements without linking them to their intended dramatic purpose.

Finally, a number of submissions exceeded the formal limits for word count and illustrations—namely, 2,400 words and five pages of visual material. It is important to emphasize that examiners are not required to assess any content beyond these limits.

Criterion B1

This criterion proved particularly challenging for many students. A common issue was the ineffective use of the 2,400 word limit. While some submissions demonstrated impressive diversity and breadth by including numerous musical selections, this often came at the expense of depth. The most successful submissions were those that found a thoughtful balance, limiting the number of pieces in order to explore each one meaningfully and connect musical findings directly to the chosen Area of Inquiry (AOI).

In a substantial number of submissions, musical observations were primarily descriptive, offering surface-level commentary rather than deeper engagement. In some cases, students relied on secondary analytical sources, which is acceptable. However, the commentary often lacked evidence of true understanding. Additionally, evidence presented frequently consisted of general stylistic traits of a genre, rather than being clearly tied to the specific selections under discussion.

Another recurring problem was the misuse of audio materials. In several submissions, the excerpts referenced in the analysis (timestamps) did not match the audio provided in Upload 3. Students who relied solely on listening for their analysis often failed to achieve the level of depth expected, particularly when the audio was not clearly integrated into their discussion.

Students are also encouraged to be selective and purposeful in the information they include. For example, anecdotal details such as a composer's travels or being taught music by their parents do not contribute meaningfully to musical analysis. Instead, emphasis should be placed on aspects that illuminate the composer's style or techniques relevant to the AOI.

Ultimately, the most effective submissions used the word count efficiently, prioritized relevance over quantity, and engaged critically with musical examples in a way that supported both analysis and contextual understanding.

Criterion B2

A noticeable number of students appeared to misunderstand the intent of this criterion, resulting in weak connections between the research findings and the practical work presented in C1 and C2. The Music Guide clearly expects students to investigate musical materials through research and then apply that understanding by creating practical exercises that demonstrate their grasp of relevant conventions. However, this progression was often absent.

In many submissions, the practical exercises were based on stimuli that had not been addressed or explored during the research phase. This disconnect suggests that the underlying purpose of the component, to bridge research and creative application, was not fully grasped. In contrast, the strongest submissions showed a clear alignment: they thoughtfully selected AOIs and contexts, investigated creating or performing conventions in depth, and then applied that knowledge with purpose. These submissions frequently received full marks.

Overall, the submissions revealed a broader issue: both students and teachers seemed unclear about how to implement the requirement concerning "implications of the research for the practical

exercises.” This gap in understanding significantly impacted the effectiveness and coherence of many projects

Criterion C1

In several submissions, students attempted to combine features from various researched works into their practical exercises. While this approach suggested creative ambition, the outcome was often unconvincing in terms of demonstrating understanding of stylistic conventions. The problem was not the idea of synthesis itself, but the lack of a clear understanding of how individual features operate within the stylistic conventions of a genre. Effective demonstrations of style rely on the deliberate organization of musical material rather than the arbitrary layering of recognizable traits.

A significant issue contributing to this confusion was the tendency to treat isolated features from a single piece as universal conventions of a style. For example, if a student studied only Mozart’s *A Musical Joke*, which uses purposeful stylistic errors, they might mistakenly assume that these errors define all the music from Mozart or the Classical period. Such conclusions stem from limited exposure and insufficient comparative analysis.

Identifying genuine stylistic conventions requires examining multiple representative works to detect patterns that consistently define a style. One cannot claim that symphonies are typically written in E-flat major just because a single symphony happens to be in that key. Without a broader musical context, students risk misinterpreting unique compositional choices as general rules.

This pattern reveals a deeper misunderstanding about the role of research in the creative process. Understanding a musical style involves more than listing features. It requires recognizing how those features function together within a structured, stylistically coherent context. When students skip this analytical step, their work lacks authenticity and stylistic clarity.

Criterion C2

This criterion proved to be the most challenging for the majority of students. A clear understanding of what constitutes a meaningful “adaptation” was often lacking, suggesting that both students and teachers may be unclear about the expectations. Rather than engaging with the stylistic and interpretative aspects of adaptation, most students submitted straightforward arrangements, variations, or transcriptions tailored to their primary instrument.

In many cases, what was labelled as an “adaptation” amounted to little more than a note-for-note transcription, frequently of just a single melodic line from the original stimulus. These versions showed little to no engagement with the original work’s performance practices, rendering the concept of adaptation essentially superficial.

Some students did attempt more complex submissions by layering multiple parts through multitrack recordings. While these efforts resulted in more complete realizations of the stimulus, they generally remained transcriptions rather than true adaptations as they still failed to demonstrate stylistic sensitivity or an understanding of how performance practices might inform the transformation.

Only a very small number of students succeeded in crafting adaptations that were both inventive and rooted in a thoughtful engagement with historical or stylistic performance practices. These few examples stood out as models of what the task is intended to foster.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

Criterion A

Students are recommended to carefully choose 3–4 musical examples that clearly relate to their context and Area of Inquiry (AOI). Using simplified versions, like piano reductions, while analyzing the full orchestration often leads to weak analysis. When available, scores should be used meaningfully and include annotations to support arguments. In genres where notation is rare (e.g. traditional music), students can show initiative by creating brief transcriptions to illustrate specific features, such as a recurring rhythm or melodic phrase.

Criterion B1

Strong submissions go beyond basic description and offer deeper insight. Top-scoring students used well-chosen examples and avoided vague or off-topic remarks. Instead of referencing external links like YouTube, students should include relevant excerpts with clear timestamps or notated excerpts. They must also point out exactly where evidence appears and use appropriate musical terminology throughout.

Criterion B2

The best submissions treated the process as an integrated whole. These students connected their initial research (section 1) with the creation and adaptation phases that followed (sections 2 and 3). By understanding that their investigation laid the foundation for later work, they could clearly explain how findings influenced their creative decisions.

Criterion C1

A convention reflects patterns shared across a style, not just features of a single piece. High-scoring students are able to distinguish between general stylistic traits and isolated musical details. For example, recognizing that pop songs *often* include chorus sections is more meaningful than noting that a song is written in 4/4 or E major.

Criterion C2

Strong submissions in this area showed an understanding of how interpretation changes across styles and cultures. A clarinet passage written in Klezmer style will not be performed the same way as one from a Beethoven symphony or a Jazz piece. Students who did well studied these traditions and applied their findings creatively—for example, mimicking Klezmer clarinet techniques on a violin by using techniques like ornaments or glissandi, in order to replicate the character of the original.

Further comments

Both students and teachers are highly encouraged to dedicate time to carefully reading and understanding the Music Guide. Many problems found in student submissions could have been prevented with closer attention to the document's instructions.

In many cases, the difficulties students encounter, whether in writing or creating, appear to result from a partial or superficial understanding of what is actually required. Prioritizing a clear and thorough comprehension of the guide from the outset will likely lead to stronger results than jumping into the composition or project work without that foundational knowledge.

Experimenting with music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

Examiners encountered work covering the full range of marks, with most of the work submitted being generally suited to the task. Many of the lowest marks were awarded to work that was poorly formulated, whilst maximum marks were more often obtained in the creating rather than the performing sections.

The requirement to include Areas of Inquiry (AOIs) and contexts was observed well this session, with most students making some attempt to justify their choices of AOI and context. Only a small minority entirely omitted identifying AOI and/or context. The requirement to not use material from a personal context was generally understood.

The requirement for unfamiliarity was observed by many students but evidence of this unfamiliarity having any effect on experimenting was practically non-existent.

Evidence of research was not always present. Students who did research and applied/included findings tended to score better across the criteria.

Some students, in their creating experiments, limited themselves to writing original material 'in the style of...' or 'influenced by...'. It was difficult for these to achieve the higher marks since they were effectively recreating exercises.

The less appropriate performing projects included exercises in learning a new piece of music or learning a new technique, or using a new device. In all these cases, the development of musical ideas through performance was inevitably limited.

Student performance against each criterion

Criteria A and C

Successful commentaries presented clearly motivated rationales, research, effective referencing and clear explanation of working decisions.

Rationales were not always present, with some students going straight into the experiments and others presenting the briefest of introductions.

Research was not always present, and only a minority of responses featured an instance of some research producing an idea that was then applied to the stimulus. Generic stylistic elements were often worked into experiments without any reference to research.

Attribution of sources was uneven, with many students often imagining it was sufficient to name the stimulus piece.

The use of unreliable source material such as MuseScore transcriptions and arrangements was more present this session. Students should be aware that files downloaded from MuseScore are not published originals but versions from private individuals with no guarantee of authenticity or

effectiveness. Whilst MuseScore files can be used, students are advised to be aware of what they are using.

Subject terminology, when used effectively, helped greatly in explaining experimenting decisions. In general, it can be said that those using examples of musical notation fared better in explaining their processes.

Performing experiments sometimes failed to give sufficient attention to the source material, making general comments about techniques in performance without pointing to where this impacted the music.

Criteria B and D

Students taking ideas from secondary stimuli (research) were more likely to demonstrate *adaptation* or *transformation* of the source material than those who worked with the elements in the material without taking in other influences.

Practical work in creating was more or less equally divided between creating with programs such as Sibelius and MuseScore, and technology creating using digital workstations, with some submissions using a combination of both.

Improvisation was used almost exclusively in performing experiments rather than as a creating activity.

Performance with live use of electronics was rare.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

The distinction between the two sections of work, creating and performing, needs to be made clear.

Teachers are encouraged to support their students' research and ensure that students integrate their musical findings effectively. Students should try to show what it is they are taking from the research to be applied in the experimentation process.

Students should remember to offer some evaluation after each experimenting excerpt. This may even be a negative evaluation if the student feels the experiment has not produced a useful result.

It is useful for examiners to be able to see the teacher's comments in the space provided on the mark entry screen on IBIS. If adding comments to the work itself, it needs to be ensured that these do not obscure any of the student's work.

It is advisable to try to make use of the full 10 minutes of audio space. Short audio entries are not penalized but will tend to offer less evidence of development of ideas and effective decision making.

The process of learning a piece or a new technique is not, in itself, an experiment.

When working with audio technology, students should remember to refer also to the musical elements in their commentaries.

Higher level the contemporary music maker

The range and suitability of the work submitted

The May 2025 session reflected continued growth in students' ability to explore music-making from a contemporary and process-driven perspective. Many students demonstrated creativity and personal engagement through a variety of roles, including composition, performance, production, and songwriting. The majority of submissions centred on the role of composer.

The strongest submissions revealed authentic artistic intentions, meaningful collaboration and compelling final outcomes. Multimedia presentations were often well-structured and offered valuable insights into the evolution of the project. Several schools showed noticeable improvement in aligning the selected evidence with the musical aims of the project. However, several recurring issues were evident across schools, highlighting areas that require further clarification and support in future sessions.

Student performance against each criterion

Criterion A

Strong submissions included multimedia materials that clearly supported the creative journey of the project. In these cases, video excerpts, annotated scores, DAW screenshots, rehearsal footage, and voice-over explanations offered a coherent narrative of development. However, a significant portion of the cohort submitted presentations that were either formulaic or overly brief, offering limited insight into the actual creative process.

In many instances, the documentation focused more on outcomes than on the creative process itself. For example, some students included only final recordings or performances with minimal explanation of how they were achieved. Others relied heavily on static slides with generic text and little audiovisual support. Weak submissions often lacked sufficient evidence of compositional strategies, rehearsal processes, or collaboration.

Common issues included unclear musical roles, overreliance on group-based language ("we did this") without individual reflection, and the absence of visual documentation of music-making (e.g., scores, DAW screenshots, or rehearsal footage). In some cases, the examiner was left with insufficient evidence to determine the student's individual contribution to the project.

Criterion B

The strongest students were able to reflect critically on their music-making journey, demonstrating awareness of both musical and collaborative processes. Their submissions described specific challenges, explained strategies for improvement, and justified the decisions taken. These students frequently employed evaluative and investigative language, demonstrating maturity in their reflection.

In contrast, many students remained at a descriptive or formulaic level, simply outlining the steps followed or restating basic project facts. The distinction between challenges and successes was often blurred or generalized, and discussions of development were either omitted or presented without supporting detail.

It was also evident that many students struggled to clearly distinguish between the different levels of response expected by the assessment command terms. For example, students often used "explains" or "describes" when attempting to meet the demands of higher-level terms such as "evaluates" or "examines." Similarly, "demonstrates" and "justifies" were frequently used interchangeably without the depth or contextualization these terms require. Providing students with structured guidance and exemplars may support more accurate use of this language and deepen their reflective practice.

Criterion C

Student achievement in Criterion C varied depending on the student's demonstrated control, skill, and musicianship in the stated role. Strong submissions displayed confident execution, whether through compelling compositional strategies, assured instrumental or vocal performances, or detailed and creative production decisions. For example, composers who showcased clear musical development through their pieces, or performers who communicated effectively through phrasing and expression, were able to demonstrate a high level of technical proficiency.

In contrast, weaker submissions often revealed limited command of musical materials or basic handling of musical tools. Some compositions lacked structural coherence or development of ideas, performances suffered from intonation, rhythmic accuracy, or expression issues, and production work sometimes showed superficial manipulation of sound without evidence of intentionality or refinement.

Criterion D

The most successful multimedia presentations were well-structured, accessible and engaging. These included voice-over explanations synchronized with audiovisual evidence, making it easy to follow the development of the project.

Weaker submissions often relied on static slides with dense text or included long periods of silence due to broken video/audio links. Some students presented only the final product, offering no insight into the development process. Others failed to make full use of the 15-minute allowance, with presentations ending after only two or three minutes.

There remains a need to encourage schools to help students explore the full potential of the multimedia format. More frequent inclusion of rehearsal footage, in-progress videos, and explanatory commentary would improve both clarity and engagement.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

Teachers and students should carefully read both parts of the CMM component in the Music Guide: the syllabus components and the internal assessment part, particularly the submission requirements.

It is crucial to plan activities with the assessment criteria in mind, especially criterion B.

Clear identification of the student submitting the work should be emphasized, such as by including a picture or video of the student and discussing their own contributions.

Submitting original material when working with arrangements is essential, as many submissions in this category lacked the original material necessary to assess the student's arrangement skills.

In cases of collaboration where students share the composition process of the same piece, clear leadership should be established for each presentation, and the music presented should be developed in depth to demonstrate excellent technical proficiency.

Students should be encouraged to effectively use supporting documents to enhance their presentations. Including as much variety as possible in facilitating the final multimedia presentation is encouraged, discouraging students from relying solely on speaking over PowerPoint slides.

Further comments

The May 2025 session reaffirmed the unique value of the Contemporary Music Maker component in fostering creative exploration. Many students embraced the challenge with commitment and originality. With continued support in documentation, reflection, and clarity of musical role, future students can further enhance the quality and depth of their submissions.

Presenting music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

The work submitted this session was mostly suitable in relation to the requirements of Presenting music. Overall, students chose appropriate repertoire for performance and creating with better connection to and reflection on the Areas of Inquiry than in previous sessions. Although there was diversity in this manner, there was not much selection of music outside of the Western musical genres and most of the styles presented were either Western Popular music or Western Art music. In performance, a range of solo instrumentation and singing was demonstrated, and in composition there was a mixture of traditional classically notated acoustic scores, music technology compositions with some musique concrète works and improvisations in jazz and other styles. Although not all the work was suitable, for example some ensemble work not having individual extracts submitted and some creating not having scores in the programme notes, most of the submissions were suitable regarding the requirements. A range of solo instruments such as piano, violin, cello, double bass, electric bass, classical and acoustic guitar, electric guitar, flute, clarinet, bassoon, trumpet, tuba, euphonium, pitched percussion, drum set, solo voice, and ensembles such as choirs, concert bands, jazz bands, full orchestras, string orchestras and rock bands (amongst others) were evident, but very few Music Technology performances were submitted.

Student performance against each criterion

Criterion A

This session showed a better understanding of the meaning behind each Area of Inquiry (AOI), with many students appropriately linking the selections chosen to an AOI and providing an explanation which justified the link. There were still submissions where the AOIs were only listed in the titles and not justified, and in some programme notes AOIs were not mentioned at all. Some programme notes had evidence of extensive research, but many of the programme notes were quite basic in the background information on each selection about cultural and historical information. Some musical details were described with regard to each piece on the programme, but little musical terminology was used in the explanations of the selections. Most of the programmes had scores for creating in the programme notes as well as an accurate track list and a bibliography to show evidence of research, but there were still some programme notes lacking details, particularly as to what instrument (or voice) the student was playing in the performing area of the submission.

Criterion B

Many submissions had, in an appropriate manner, two compositions, one being an acoustic composition with a traditionally notated score and the second a music technology score, both of similar length. Some traditionally notated scores lacked expressive details such as dynamics, articulation, tempo markings and even instrumentation. There were compositions showing an excellent understanding of orchestration but, unfortunately, other compositions which showed little research as to the actual technical demands of the acoustic instruments written in the score. These

scores seemed to have been written using notation software without much consideration as to how the music would actually be played by live musicians. There was improvement in the music technology compositions but there were still many works relying on simple loops repeated with very little variation or development. Some submissions showed excellent use of effects and technology, but others were mostly midi realisations of music notation scores made on software such as MuseScore without further expansion, editing and addition of effects.

Criterion C

The repertoire chosen was mostly at a suitable level according to the individual student's capabilities but there were still some selections chosen that were either beyond the technical level of the student or at times not quite challenging enough to show the full technical capability of the student. The level of the ensembles was better this session and usually the student's solo extracts were at a similar level with the full ensemble's level. There were, however, still submissions lacking extracts. In both the solo and ensemble playing and singing, there is still room for improvement in the areas of intonation and tone production. Stylistically, more differentiation is needed to show the characteristics of each genre clearly.

Criterion D

When the AOIs were clearly explained and justified in the programme notes, the musical communication of those roles was also usually competent. The majority of the submissions showed musicality and expression in the playing and creating.

Audio quality showed improvement this session but there were still submissions that had unclear sound which made it extremely difficult to discern the actual role of the student in the performance.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

Criterion A

Teachers are recommended to make sure that students understand the connection between the repertoire and the AOIs, and to make sure that what is on the track list in the programme notes is the same as what is written on the 6/MPM form. Teachers should help the students choose a wide range of repertoire for performing and aid students in starting their creating early in the course so that the student can afterwards select a diverse range of performances and compositions for the final submission. Evidence of academic research is needed in the programme notes for each of the selections performed or created. Referencing for any audio quotations used in music technology compositions or performances must be in the programme note's bibliography as well as referencing for written quotations.

Criterion B

Creating must be accompanied by a score (either acoustic or annotated screen shots of the DAW used). The video upload section is only for Music Technology performing and not for creating.

The writing for acoustic instruments needs to be technically possible to be played by a live musician even if a midi realisation is submitted for the audio. Expressive markings need to be in the score and music technology scores need annotations to explain the techniques and effects used. A plan or set of short scores of the initial motifs, chord progressions and/or structure should be in the programme notes for improvisations to evidence the work and practice behind the improvisation. Scores should not have the name of the student in the area that normally has 'composer' in a published score.

Criterion C

The student must be clear in the programme notes what instrument or voice type has been played/sung by the student. Instruments need to be tuned properly before performances and pianos of a decent standard should be played upon, otherwise the tone colour (and pedalling effects) will be negligible. Ensemble submissions must have a solo extract of the student to demonstrate the technical and musical competency of the student and not just the ensemble's level. Sets of performances of the student playing a range of instruments and singing are acceptable but the teacher should advise the student to choose the instrument(s)/voice that shows their technical level and ability to interpret performance practices at their best.

Criterion D

The audio needs to be clear and not have background voices or other performances sounding at the same time. Clarification in the programme notes as to the meaning of the selections performed and created in relation to the AOIs aid in the musical communication of the roles as well as enhancing musical expression.

Further comments

This session's work had evidence of a good grasp of what is required for Presenting regarding selecting the performance and creating repertoire and writing appropriate programme notes. Despite the recommendations already mentioned, there were exemplary submissions showing an accomplished level of technical proficiency as well as musicality and expression in the performing and creating.